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More Things in Heaven and Earth

The air smelled of stale hops, as usual, and the sky over the city was a dull, low gray. The cobblestone street below had a slight rise to it as it curved around the hill. The hill itself was notable simply for existing, since the entire city was built on a low-lying island. Yet there it was, a small green hill surrounded by a low stone wall, impossibly situated on the outskirts of Copenhagen. Around the corner, a man appeared. He was on the early side of middle-aged, wearing a suit and a pair of thick, black-rimmed glasses. His hair was dark and receding noticeably. He walked along the wall, then crossed the street and went up to the gates of the Carlsberg Brewery itself. It was November 17, 1962, a Saturday, and Thomas Kuhn was here to see the man who had resided in the Carlsberg House of Honor for the past thirty years: Niels Bohr.

Kuhn was the director of the brand-new Archives for the History of Quantum Physics at UC Berkeley. A physicist by training, Kuhn had taken an interest in the history of his field while studying for his PhD at Harvard, and now, fifteen years later, he was a professor of history at Berkeley. For the past few months, and for the next two years, Kuhn and his team of assistants were traveling the world, interviewing the surviving members of the heroic generation who had first uncovered the laws of quantum physics: Heisenberg, de Broglie, Born, Dirac, and many more. Einstein and Schrödinger were already dead by the time the project started, as was Pauli, but Kuhn and his team worked to compile their papers as well and assemble a sketch of the work the men had done, all with an eye toward aiding